

FOSS and Higher Education: Made for Each Other, but not Strong Partners

It is such good technology, so easy to learn, promotes a sharing culture and could allow Indian techies, in particular, to get a very deep understanding of how tech works. So FOSS ought to be a big hit in education, right?

Wrong. FOSS, or free and open source software, still continues to get step-motherly treatment in the world of education, across various parts of the globe. This is true of the US and it's also true of India, a country that could play a decisive role in charting the course of the software of tomorrow.

Recently, Gina Likins (@lintqueen) and Matt Bernius (@mattbernius) gave an interesting talk on this subject, which makes one think deeper. The Free Software Foundation tweeted: "What college students do and don't know about free software?" and pointed to LibrePlanet 2018 (<https://u.fsf.org/2jl>).

In their talk, design anthropologist Bernius and open source in education evangelist Likins (also a Red Hatter) look at FOSS in the US context. But what they say would apply to other parts of the globe too. The crucial question they ask is, "Are today's college computer science students being taught core free software tools and concepts?"

The reality is surprising. In 2014-15, around 60,000 students graduated with computing and programming degrees across the US. Students who took up these subjects but did not specialise in them would be 200,000, in the US alone. Yet, very few engage in FOSS projects. So, what's blocking them? And how can FOSS community members help?

At one level, there is a high level of interest and excitement around FOSS issues. Students talk articulately about their interest in FOSS – about everything from making things, to building a better world; from framing the issue in political terms to programming terms. "But once we went beyond the theoretical, things went south very swiftly," comment Likins and Bernius.

There are many issues here. The majority of students are not learning FOSS in classes but from other students. At the core, there is a small group who really understands what it means to participate, and *how* to participate in FOSS. But beyond the inner circles, it's quite like a broken telephone. There is a lot of ignorance about how to participate. Sharing a project on GitHub doesn't make it open source, Likins and Bernius point out. Students working on FOSS sometimes fail to get their work accepted because they opt for the wrong licences.

